

Letters and e-mails

LETTERS AND E-MAILS ARE FORMS OF CORRESPONDENCE ADDRESSED TO A SPECIFIC PERSON OR GROUP.

Different types of correspondence are used in certain situations, for different purposes. It is important to set out each type correctly.

Formal letters

Formal letters are written to someone the writer doesn't know, or to someone in authority, such as a teacher or a politician. Examples of formal letters include job application letters and complaint letters. People send complaint letters about faulty products or bad service in a hotel or restaurant.

SEE ALSO

◀ **118–119** Numbers, dates, and time

◀ **188–189** Paragraphing

◀ **196–197** Writing to inform

Writing to influence **202–203** ▶

Writing to explain or advise **204–205** ▶

Writing from personal experience **210–211** ▶

The **first e-mail** was sent in **1971**. Today, more than **294 billion** e-mails are sent every day.

The recipient's address needs to be written here.

Use the recipient's title and surname in formal letters.

Mr. Santa Claus
Toy Workshop
Secret Mountain
North Pole

Ian Brat
92 Maple Street
Sunnydale, OH 44096
USA

The sender's address needs to be included at the top.

December 26, 2013

The date also goes at the top.

Re: Crummy Christmas present. Child no. 12,231,923,000

Formal letters often include a subject heading, which tells the recipient what the letter is about.

Dear Mr. Claus,

I have always been delighted with your quality products and your efficient and professional delivery service. Thus, I was very surprised when I had such a bad experience this year.

Starting a complaint letter with something positive will make the letter sound reasonable.

On November 15, 2013, I sent you a comprehensive Christmas present list. However, all I received on Christmas Day was a pair of navy blue socks. They are at least three sizes too big and have a hole in the left toe.

Complaint letters need to give specific details.

I appreciate that you are very busy and mistakes are bound to occur. Therefore, I would be happy to accept one of the gifts that I asked for in my original list (please find enclosed). In this case, I wouldn't have to take the matter any further.

Sign off with a complimentary close, such as *Yours truly* or *Sincerely*.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours truly,
Ian Brat